From Style to Prompt: Creating Images with an Art Historian's Eye

Teaching with AI (TAI)

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Subject: Art styles and image prompting
Activity duration: 90 min

Steps:

1. Art Styles (45 minutes)
    - Motivation + Assignment 1: spot the difference (15 min)
    - Assignment 2: mystery image (30 min)
2. Prompting images (45 minutes)
    - Assignment 3: reverse engineer your mystery image (10 min)
    - Assignment 4: swap and guess (10 min)
    - Assignment 5: create a logo (25 min)

Learning goals:

- Art styles have common visual features.
- Distinguish art styles in paintings and photographs.
- Using AI to learn responsibly: describe images, request verification links from museums, and cross-check facts
- How to prompt to obtain the image you want
- Create a logo

Setup:

- Students need access to an AI LLM chat bot, and an AI image generation tool.
- The teacher provides and prints mystery artworks for every pair or students.
- The teacher prints a Style Feature Guide and Style Card for every pair of students.

From style to prompt

Creating images with an art historian's eye

Modern AI image generators can create images in all kind of styles. For example, since they have been trained on many famous artworks, they can therefore reproduce the style of famous artists or art styles. This gives anyone the chance to, without being a master painter, create an image of their wish in the style of, let's say, Vincent van Gogh. We give the style as part of a textual prompt to the model, and it creates an image.
This creates an opportunity, but is also a challenge: we need to be able to *describe the image we want to create in words*. Sometimes, it is not easy to express in words why we like a painting, photograph or drawing. In this lesson, you will learn about different art styles and their main visual features. Then, you will practice with creating your own images with AI.

Assignment 1: Spot the difference

Your teacher will show two paintings and two photographs. Also, you will receive a Style Guide. Work with a partner to identify what makes the pairs of paintings and photographs different in style. Use the Style Guide to make the differences concrete.

Pair A: paintings

Question 1: Come up with a name for the paintings.

- Name for Painting 1

- Name for Painting 2

Question 2: Describe the differences between the paintings in your own words.

Question 3: Look at the Style Guide and find two style features present in Painting 1 but not in Painting 2.

Question 4: Now find two style features present in Painting 2 but not Painting 1.

Pair B: photographs

Question 5: Come up with a name for the photos.

- Name for Photo 1
- Name for Photo 2

Question 6: Describe the differences between the photographs in your own words.

Question 7: Look at the Style Guide and find two style features present in Photo 1 but not in Photo 2.

Question 8: Now find two style features present in Photo 2 but not Photo 1.

1 Art Styles

Some combinations of style features are often used together. This gives collections of paintings that are often made in a certain period of time a similar look. These looks are described by art styles like realism, impressionism or Art Nouveau, for example.
In the next assignment, you will try to figure out the art style of a given piece of art, by first identifying the style features.

Assignment 2: Mystery art work

a) As a group of 2-3 students you receive an image of a mystery artwork. Fill out the questions below for your assigned mystery artwork.

Initial impression

Question 9: Group members' names (2–3)

Question 10: When do you guess that this artwork was created?

Question 11: Do you have an idea what art style it could be?

Question 12: What do you like or dislike about the artwork

Question 13: Using the Style Guide, write down three style features of this artwork

Art Style identification

For the upcoming questions about the identification of the style, you can use an LLM assistent to help you.
Some helpful prompts:

"Based on this description of a painting: [1–2 sentences describing what you see], identify likely art style(s). List 3 signature visual features, 2 artists connected to that style, and a typical date range. Include 1 museum link to verify. Keep under 100 words."

"List 3 public-domain artworks that exemplify [style], with museum links."

"Provide 2 museum or academic links that confirm these features for [style]. Summarize what each source confirms in one sentence."

Make sure that you verify your information with trustworthy sources, for example museum web pages.

Question 14: What are the artist and title of the artwork?

Question 15: What art style(s) does the artwork belong to?

Question 16: What date range did this art style thrive?

Question 17: What region or movement does this art style originate from?

Question 18: List three visual hallmarks of the style that can be seen in your mystery image

Question 19: Two other artists associated with this style

Question 20: One other representative artwork (not the mystery artwork) (title + artist + date)

Question 21: Why did this style emerge? (e.g., social change, technology, philosophy)

Citations (paste URLs)

Question 22: Source 1 (museum/academic)

Question 23: Source 2 (optional)

Evaluation

Question 24: How did you use AI to fill out your style card?

Question 25: How did you verify that the information that the AI gave you was correct?

b) Write the name of the art style on your given mystery image and collect all of them in the front of the class. Take a look at the different images and styles.

Question 26: Which artwork and style do you like, and why? Describe it in terms of aspects in the Style Guide.

2 Image generation with AI

The rest of this lesson we will generate images ourselves. We will create a personalized prompting template that we can use in the future, to help us create the images we want.

Assignment 3: Reverse engineer your mystery artwork

a) Open an AI Image generation program. Without using the name of the artist and artwork, try to recreate the piece of art that you received as a mystery artwork. Make use of the style features you collected in the previous exercise, and try to describe what you see as well as possible.

Question 27: Paste your prompt here.

b) You will now receive a Prompt Guide from your teacher. Repeat the exercise and rewrite/improve your prompt using the tips.

Question 28: Paste your new prompt here.

Question 29: Compare the images created by the two versions of the prompt. What are the most important differences?

Question 30: What tip did you find useful?

Question 31: What would you add to the tips? Add them to your personalized Prompt Guide.

c) Finally, put the best version of your prompt in an AI chat bot, and ask it to help you improve it even more. Say that you want to create the mystery painting (title, artist) without using the title and artist.

Question 32: Paste the final version of your prompt here.

Question 33: Ask your AI Chatbot for more tips to write prompts for images and add the ones you like to your personal Prompt Guide.

Assignment 4: Swap and guess

a) Describe a scene from a book, movie or TV series that you like. You will use this later to generate an image.

b) Generate an image of the scene you described, using your personal Prompt Guide. Each student generates one. Save your prompt and the image.

Question 34: Write your prompt here.

c) Exchange images with a neighbor. Try to guess the prompt that your neighbor used.

Question 35: Write your guess prompt for your neighbors image here.

d) Try out the guess prompt and compare it to the original image. Also compare the prompts. Discuss what details were essential or missing.

Question 36: Which parts of the prompt did you miss?

Question 37: Why is it impossible to recreate the image exactly?

Assignment 5: Logo creation

a) In teams of 2 or 3, create a logo for the Teaching in AI (TAI) project. We will vote for the best logo, which will be used on the website and the publication of all the teaching material of this project. The logo will be seen by all the teachers and students learning from this material like you do now.

Tips:

- Consider the target audience and think about what they would like.
- You can chat with an LLM to come up with ideas, that you can then translate into a prompt.

Afterwards, answer the following question.

Question 38: Which aspects of today's lesson did you use in the design of your logo?